

I THE LITTLE SHOE

At the moment when the truands launched their assault on the church, la Esmeralda was sleeping.

Soon the ever-increasing uproar round the building and the anxious bleating of her goat, which had already woken up, roused her from sleep. She sat up, listened, looked, and then, frightened by the glow and the noise, rushed out of the cell and went to look. The appearance of the square, the sight astir there, the disorder of this night attack, the hideous crowd, hopping up and down like a horde of frogs, dimly spied in the darkness, the hoarse croaking of this multitude, the few red torches speeding along and passing each other against the background of shadow, like the fires to be seen at night streaking over the misty surface of marshes, the whole scene looked to her like some mysterious battle being waged between the phantoms of a witches' sabbath and the stone monsters of the church. Imbued from childhood with the superstitions of the Bohemian tribe, her first thought was that she had surprised at their evil spells the strange beings of the night. So she ran back in terror to cower in her cell, asking her pallet for a nightmare less full of horror.

Gradually, however, the first vapours of fear cleared away; the noise, constantly increasing, and several other signs of reality, made her realize that her besiegers were not spectres but human beings. This did not increase her fright, but transformed it. She thought about the possibility of a popular insurrection to snatch her from her refuge. The idea of yet again losing life, hope, Phoebus, whom she still glimpsed in her future, the absolute void in which her weakness left her, all escape cut off, unsupported, abandoned, isolated, all these thoughts and countless others overwhelmed her. She fell to her knees, her head on the bed, hands clasped upon her head, filled with anxiety and trembling, and though a gypsy, idolatrous and pagan, she began sobbing to beg mercy of the good Christian God and to pray to Our Lady, her hostess. For, even if one believes in nothing, there are moments in life when one always holds the religion of the temple closest to hand.

She remained prostrate like that for a very long time, trembling, in truth, rather than praying, chilled as the breath of the raging multitude came nearer and nearer, understanding nothing of their frenzy, knowing nothing of what was planned, what they were doing, what they intended, but filled with a premonition of some dreadful outcome.

Then, in the midst of her anguish she heard footsteps nearby. She turned round. Two men, one carrying a lantern, had just entered her cell. She let out a feeble cry.

'Don't be afraid,' said a voice not unknown to her, 'it's me.'

'Who? Who are you?' she asked.

'Pierre Gringoire.'

The name reassured her. She looked up, and indeed recognized the poet. But next to him was a figure dressed in black and veiled from head to foot who struck her dumb.

'Ah!' Gringoire went on reproachfully, 'Djali recognized me before you did!'

The little goat had indeed not waited for Gringoire to announce his name. He had barely come in before she was fondly rubbing against his knees, covering the poet with caresses and white hairs, for she was moulting. Gringoire returned her caresses.

'Who's that with you?' the gypsy said in a low voice.

'Don't worry,' Gringoire answered. 'It's a friend of mine.'

At that the philosopher, setting his lantern on the floor, crouched down on the flagstones and exclaimed enthusiastically as he hugged Djali in his arms: 'Oh! what a graceful animal, no doubt more notable for her cleanliness than her size, but ingenious, subtle, and as well lettered as a grammarian! Let's see, my Djali, have you forgotten any of your pretty tricks? How does Maître Jacques Charmolue go ...?'

The man in black did not let him finish. He came up to Gringoire and pushed him roughly by the shoulder. Gringoire stood up. 'It's true,' he said, 'I was forgetting that we are in a hurry—but that's no reason, master, to rage at people so. My dear, fair child, your life is in danger, and so is Djali's. They want to hang you again. We are your friends, and we have come to save you. Follow us.'

'Is that true?' she cried, quite overcome.

'Yes, quite true. Come quickly!'

'I will,' she stammered. 'But why doesn't your friend speak?'

'Ah!' said Gringoire, 'it's because his father and mother were whimsical people who gave him a taciturn disposition.'

She had to be content with that explanation. Gringoire took her by the hand, his companion picked up the lantern and walked in front. The girl was stunned by fear. She let herself be led. The goat skipped after them, so happy to see Gringoire again that she kept making him stumble by sticking her horns between his legs. 'That's life!' said the philosopher each time he just missed falling; 'it's often our best friends who cause our downfall!' They hurried down the tower stairs, crossed the church, all dark and lonely, but echoing with the uproar, which made a dreadful contrast, and came out into the cloister garth by the Red Door. The cloister was abandoned, the canons had fled to the bishop's palace to pray there together; the garth was empty, with a few terrified servants hiding in dark corners. They made for the door giving on to the Terrain from this courtyard. The man in black opened it with a key he had. Our readers know that the Terrain was a spit of land enclosed by walls on the Cité side, belonging to the chapter of Notre-Dame, and it formed the eastern tip of the island behind the church. They found this enclosure completely deserted. There the noise of tumult in the air was already fainter. The sounds of the truands' attack reached them more confusedly and with less clamour. The cool breeze blowing downstream stirred the leaves of the single tree planted at the tip of the Terrain quite audibly. However, they were still very close to danger. The nearest buildings to them were the bishop's palace and the church. There was obviously a great commotion going on inside the palace. Its dark mass was all crisscrossed with lights hurrying from one window to another; just as, when you have been burning paper, there remains a dark pile of ash through which live sparks run in countless peculiar patterns. Next to it, the enormous towers of Notre-Dame, seen thus from behind with the long nave over which they rise, silhouetted in black against the vast, red glow filling the Parvis, looked like the two gigantic firedogs of a Cyclopean fire.

What could be seen of Paris on every side wavered as one looked in a blend of light and shade. Some of Rembrandt's pictures have that sort of background.

The man with the lantern walked straight to the tip of the Terrain. There, at the very edge of the water, were the decaying remains of a fence made of stakes with

laths laid across them to which a low vine clung with a few meagre branches sticking out like the fingers of an open hand. Behind, in the shadow cast by this trellis, a small boat lay hidden. The man beckoned to Gringoire and his companion to get into it. The goat followed. The man stepped in last. Then he cut the boat's moorings, pushed it away from the bank with a long hook, and seizing a pair of oars, sat down in the bows, rowing with all his might towards the open water. The Seine runs very fast at that spot, and he had some trouble clearing the tip of the island.

Gringoire's first concern on getting into the boat was to take the goat on his knees. He installed himself in the stern, and the girl, in whom the stranger inspired an indefinable anxiety, came to sit pressed closely against the poet.

When the philosopher felt the boat moving, he clapped his hands and kissed Djali between her horns. 'Oh!' he said, 'now all four of us are safe.' He added, with the expression of a profound thinker: 'One is obliged, sometimes to fortune, sometimes to cunning, for the happy outcome of great enterprises.'

The boat moved slowly towards the right bank. The girl watched the stranger with secret terror. He had carefully stopped up the light from his dark lantern. He could be dimly seen in the bows of the boat, like a spectre in the dark. His hood, still lowered, had the effect of a kind of mask, and each time he opened his arms as he rowed, with the wide black sleeves hanging down, they looked like two huge batwings. For the rest, he had still not said a word, let out a breath. There was no other sound in the boat but the oars going in and out, mingled with the constant rippling of the water against the sides.

'Upon my soul!' Gringoire suddenly exclaimed, 'we are as bright and cheerful as [if we had all been changed into owls like] Ascalaphus! * We are observing silence like so many Pythagoreans or fish! *Pasque-Dieu!* my friends, I'd like someone to speak to me—the human voice comes as music to the human ear. It's not I who say so, but Didymus of Alexandria, and they are famous words—to be sure, Didymus of Alexandria is no mean philosopher. A word, my lovely child! speak a word to me, I beseech you! That reminds me, you had a funny way of making a special little pout; do you still do it? Do you know, my dear, that Parliament has full jurisdiction over places of asylum, and that you were in great danger in your cell in Notre-Dame? Alas! the little trochilus bird makes its nest in the crocodile's mouth. Master, there's the

moon coming out again—I only hope no one spots us! We are performing a laudable act by rescuing mademoiselle, yet they'd hang us by order of the King if they caught us. Alas! there are two ways of taking human actions. I am condemned for what earns you a prize. The man who admires Caesar blames Catilina. Isn't it so, master? What do you say to such philosophy? For my part I possess the philosophy of instinct, of nature, *ut apes geometriam* [as bees do geometry].* Come on! no one answers me. What a tiresome mood you're both in! I'll have to talk all by myself. In tragedy it's what we call a monologue. *Pasque-Dieu!*—I warn you that I've just been seeing King Louis XI and it's from him that I've caught that oath—*Pasque-Dieu!* then! They are still making the devil of a row in the Cité. He's a nasty evil old king. He's all wrapped up in furs. He still owes me money for my epithalamium, and he came within an ace of having me hanged this evening, which I should have found most embarrassing. He's stingy with men of merit. He really ought to read the four books of Salvian of Cologne *Adversus avaritiam* [*Against Avarice*]. Truly! he is anything but generous in his treatment of men of letters, and he goes in for the most barbaric cruelties. He's a sponge for soaking up money laid upon the people. His savings are like the spleen, which swells up as all the other parts grow lean. So complaints against the rigours of the times become murmurings against the prince. Under this mild and pious lord the gallows creak with all those hanged, the headsman's blocks go rotten with blood, the prisons burst like overstuffed bellies. This king grabs with one hand and hangs with the other. He is procurator to Dame Gabelle* and my lord Gibbet. The great are stripped of their dignities, and the small ceaselessly burdened with new exactions. He's a monstrous prince. I don't like this monarch. What about you, master?'

The man in black let the garrulous poet run on. He continued to struggle against the violent, compressed current separating the prow of the Cité from the poop of the Île Notre-Dame, which today we call the Île Saint-Louis.

'By the way, master,' Gringoire suddenly went on, 'as we came out on to the Parvis through those crazy truands, did your reverence notice the poor little devil whose brains your deaf man was busy dashing out against the balustrade of the gallery of kings? I'm shortsighted and couldn't recognize him. Do you know who it might be?'

The stranger did not answer a word. But he stopped rowing abruptly, his arms gave way as if they were broken, his head slumped on his breast, and la Esmeralda

heard him heave a convulsive sigh. She trembled too. She had heard someone sigh like that before.

The boat, left to itself, drifted for a moment or two with the stream. But the man in black finally straightened up, gripped the oars again, and continued upstream. He rounded the tip of the Île Notre-Dame, and made for the landing stage at the Port-au-Foin.

'Ah!' said Gringoire, 'there's the Logis Barbeau over there. Look, master, see, that group of dark roofs at peculiar angles, there, beneath that heap of low, ragged, dirty, smeared clouds, where the moon looks all squashed and spread out like an egg yolk when the shell is broken—it's a fine mansion. There's a chapel crowned by a little vault full of nicely carved decorations. Above it you can see the very delicately pierced bell tower. There's also a pleasant garden, consisting of a pond, an aviary, an echo, a mall, a maze, a wild animal house, and a good many leaf-shaded walks most agreeable to Venus. There's also a rascally tree they call "the lecher", because it served for the pleasures of a famous princess and a gallant and witty constable of France,—alas! we poor philosophers are to a constable what a bed of cabbages and radishes is to the garden of the Louvre. What does it matter after all? Human life for the great as for us is a mixture of good and bad. Grief is always next to joy, the spondee next to the dactyl. Master, I must tell you the story of the Logis Barbeau. It ended tragically. It was in 1319, in the reign of Philippe V,* the longest of any king of France. The moral of the story is that the temptations of the flesh are pernicious and malignant. Let us not look too hard at our neighbour's wife, however susceptible our senses may be to beauty. Fornication is a most licentious thought. Adultery is curiosity about the sensual pleasure of another ... Oh! the noise is louder than ever over there!'

The uproar was indeed increasing around Notre-Dame. They listened. Cries of victory could be clearly heard. Suddenly a hundred torches, which made the soldiers' helmets sparkle, spread over the church, at every height, on the towers, on the galleries, under the flying buttresses. The torches seemed to be searching for something; and soon the distant shouts reached the fugitives distinctly: 'The gypsy! The witch! Death to the gypsy!'

The unfortunate girl dropped her head into her hands, and the stranger began

rowing furiously towards the bank. Meanwhile our philosopher reflected. He hugged the goat in his arms, and very gently moved away from the gypsy, who was huddling closer and closer to him, as her sole remaining refuge.

Gringoire was, to be sure, cruelly perplexed. He was thinking that the goat too 'according to existing legislation' would be hanged if recaptured; that that would be a great pity, poor Djali! that to have two females condemned to death clinging to him like this was really too much; that anyhow his companion would be only too happy to take on the gypsy. A violent conflict raged in his mind, in which, like Jupiter in the *Iliad*, he weighed up the gypsy and the goat in turn; and he looked at them, one after the other, his eyes moist with tears, as he said between his teeth: 'Yet I can't save you both.'

A sudden jolt told them at last that the boat had reached the bank. The sinister hubbub still filled the Cité. The stranger stood up, came over to the gypsy and tried to take her arm to help her to alight. She pushed him away and clung to Gringoire's sleeve, while he, in his turn, busy with the goat, almost pushed her away. So she jumped down from the boat by herself. She was so upset that she did not know what she was doing, or where she was going. She stayed for a moment in a daze, watching the water flow by. When she recovered her senses a little she was alone on the landing stage with the stranger. Gringoire had apparently taken advantage of the moment of landing to slip away with the goat into the block of houses in the rue Grenier-sur-l'Eau.

The poor gypsy shuddered at seeing herself alone with this man. She tried to speak, to cry out, to call Gringoire; her tongue lay inert in her mouth, and no sound came from her lips. Suddenly she felt the stranger's hand upon her own. It was a cold, strong hand. Her teeth chattered, she went paler than the moonlight shining upon her. The man did not say a word. He began striding up towards the Place de Grève, holding her by the hand. At that moment she had a vague feeling that destiny is an irresistible force. She had no energy left, she let herself be pulled along, running while he walked. The quay at that point ran upwards. It seemed to her, however, that she was going down a slope.

She looked in every direction. Not a soul passing by. The quay was absolutely deserted. She could hear no sound, detect no sign of human movement save from the

Cité, in uproar and glowing red, separated from her only by an arm of the Seine, and from whence her own name reached her mixed with cries of death. The rest of Paris lay spread out around her in great blocks of shadow.

The stranger, meanwhile, was still pulling her along as silently and swiftly as ever. She did not recognize from her memory any of the places where she was walking. As she went past a lighted window, she made an effort, stiffened up abruptly, and cried: 'Help!'

The citizen whose window it was opened it, appeared in his nightshirt with his lamp, looked at the quay bemusedly, said a few words she could not catch, and closed his shutter again. Her last glimmer of hope was extinguished.

The man in black did not utter a syllable; he held her firmly and stepped out again more quickly. She offered no further resistance, and followed him, shattered.

From time to time she gathered up a little strength and said in a voice made jerky from the unevenness of the cobbles and their breathless rush: 'Who are you? Who are you?' He did not answer.

So they arrived, always following the quay, at a quite large square. There was a little light from the moon. It was the Grève. Standing in the middle a kind of black cross could be made out. It was the gibbet. She recognized it and saw where she was.

The man stopped, turned to her and raised his hood. 'Oh!' she stammered, petrified, 'I knew it was him again!'

It was the priest. He looked like his own ghost. Moonlight has that effect. By that light one seems to see only the spectres of things.

'Listen,' he said, and she shuddered at the sound of that voice of ill omen which she had not heard for so long. He continued. He spoke in short, gasping bursts, revealing the tremors deep within. 'Listen. We are here. I'm going to talk to you. This is the Grève. It is an extreme point. Destiny has delivered us up to one another. I'm going to decide your life; you, my soul. Beyond this place and this night there is nothing to be seen. So listen to me. I'm going to tell you.... First of all don't talk to me about your Phoebus.' (As he said that, he walked to and fro, like a man who cannot stand still, pulling her after him.) 'Don't talk about him. You see? If you utter that name, I don't know what I shall do, but it will be terrible.'

With that said, like a body returning to its centre of gravity, he became motionless once more. But his words revealed just as much agitation. His voice sank lower and lower.

'Don't turn your head away like that. Listen to me. This is a serious matter. First of all, this is what has happened—it won't be anything to laugh about, I swear—what was I saying then? Remind me! Ah!—there's a decree of Parliament sending you back to the scaffold. I've just pulled you out of their hands. But there they are, pursuing you. Look!'

He stretched out his arm towards the Cité. The search did indeed appear to be continuing there. The rumblings were coming closer. The tower of the lieutenant's house, opposite the Grève, was full of noise and lights, and soldiers could be seen running along the quay opposite with torches, shouting: 'The gypsy! Where's the gypsy? Death! death!'

'You see, they are after you, and I'm not lying. I love you—don't open your mouth, or rather don't speak if it's just to say you hate me. I'm determined to hear no more of that. I've just saved you—let me finish first—I can save you completely. I have got everything ready. It's for you to wish it. As you wish, so I can do.'

He interrupted himself violently: 'No, that's not what I must say.'

Then hurrying, and making her hurry, for he did not let her go, he made straight for the gibbet, and, pointing it out to her with his finger: 'Choose between the two of us,' he said coldly.

She tore herself from his grasp and fell at the foot of the gibbet, clasping the funereal support. Then she half turned her lovely head and looked at the priest over her shoulder. She was like a Holy Virgin at the foot of the Cross. The priest had remained motionless, finger still pointing at the gibbet, holding his gesture, like a statue.

At last the gypsy said to him: 'That does not fill me with as much loathing as you do.'

At that he slowly lowered his arm, and looked at the pavement in deepest despondency. 'If those stones could speak,' he murmured, 'yes, they would say: "There is a most unhappy man."'

He went on. The girl kneeling before the gibbet, covered by her long, flowing hair, let him speak without interruption. His tone was now sorrowful and gentle, contrasting painfully with the lofty harshness of his features.

'Yes, I love you. Oh! yet it is quite true. So nothing shows outwardly of the fire burning my heart! Alas! girl, night and day, yes, night and day, does that deserve no pity? The love goes on night and day, I tell you, torture! Oh! I am suffering too much, my poor child!—it is something worthy of compassion, I assure you. You see that I am talking to you gently. I want you to stop loathing me so much—anyhow, if a man loves a woman, it's not his fault! O God! What! will you never forgive me then—will you always hate me? So it's finished! That's what makes me evil, you see, and loathsome to myself! You won't even look at me! You are thinking of something else perhaps while I stand talking to you, shivering on the brink of the eternity that faces us both! Above all don't talk to me about that officer! Why! I could cast myself at your knees; why! I could kiss, not your feet, you wouldn't want that, but the ground beneath your feet; why! I could sob like a child, I could rip from my breast not just words, but my heart and my entrails to tell you I love you, but it would all be in vain, all of it! And yet you have nothing in your soul but affection and mildness, you radiate the most lovely sweetness, you are wholly gentle, kind, merciful, and delightful. Alas! your spite is reserved for me alone! Oh! what a fatality!'

He buried his face in his hands. The girl heard him weeping. It was the first time. Standing like that, shaken by sobs, he was more wretched and imploring than on his knees. He wept like that for a while.

'Well now!' he continued, once these first tears were over, 'I am lost for words. And yet I had thought out what I was going to say to you. Now I'm trembling and shivering, I'm failing at the decisive moment, I feel something supreme enfolding us, and I stammer. Oh! I shall fall to the pavement if you don't take pity on me, pity on yourself. Don't condemn us both. If you only knew how much I love you! What kind of heart is mine! Oh! all virtue forsaken! my own self abandoned in despair! Learned doctor, I make mock of learning; gentleman, I besmirch my name; priest, I use the missal as a pillow for lust, I spit in the face of my God! All for you, enchantress—to be more worthy of your hell! And you want nothing to do with a man damned! Oh! I must tell you all! Still more, something even more horrible, oh! more horrible!'

As he uttered those last words, his manner became quite distraught. He fell silent for a moment, then went on, as though talking to himself, in a loud voice: 'Cain, what have you done with your brother?'

There was another silence, then he continued: 'What have I done with him, Lord? I took him in, I brought him up, I fed him, I loved him, I idolized him, and I killed him! Yes, Lord, they have just now dashed his head before my eyes against the stones of your house, and it is because of me, because of this woman, because of her....'

He was wild-eyed. His voice fading away, he repeated several times more, mechanically, at quite long intervals, like a bell drawing out its last vibrations: 'Because of her ... because of her ... !' Then his tongue stopped forming any perceptible sound, but his lips still continued to move. Suddenly he collapsed like something falling to pieces, and remained motionless on the ground, his head between his knees.

The girl's light touch as she withdrew her foot from under him made him come round. He ran his hand slowly over his sunken cheeks, and looked for a few moments in amazement at his fingers, which were damp. 'Why!' he murmured, 'I've been crying!'

And abruptly turning to the gypsy in indescribable anguish: 'Alas! you watched coldly as I wept! Child, do you know that those tears are burning lava? Is it really true then—nothing can move us in a man we hate? If you saw me dying you would only laugh. Oh! I don't want to see you die! One word! A single word of forgiveness! Don't tell me you love me, just tell me you are willing, that will be enough, I'll save you. Otherwise ... Oh! time is passing, I beg you by all that is sacred, don't wait for me to become stone again like that gibbet which claims you too! Just think that I hold our two destinies in my hand, that I am out of my mind—this is dreadful—that I may let everything fall, and that beneath us is a bottomless abyss, unhappy girl, down which my fall will follow yours through all eternity! One kind word! Say one word! just one word!'

She opened her mouth to answer. He flung himself to his knees before her to receive in adoration the word, perhaps of pity, about to come from her lips. She said: 'You are a murderer!'

The priest in a frenzy took her into his arms and began to laugh an abominable

laugh: 'All right then, yes! murderer!' he said, 'and I shall have you. You won't have me as your slave, so you'll have me as your master. I'll have you! I have a lair and I'll drag you there. You'll follow me, you'll have to follow me, or I'll hand you over to them! You must die, my lovely, or be mine! Be the priest's! the apostate's! the murderer's! This very night, do you hear? Come now! joy! come! Kiss me, foolish girl! The grave or my bed!'

His eyes flashed with lust and rage. His lascivious mouth left red marks on the girl's throat. She struggled in his arms. He covered her with slaverling kisses.

'Don't bite me, monster!' she cried. 'Oh! vile, loathsome monk! let me go! I'll tear out your horrid grey hair in handfuls and throw it in your face.'

He went red, he went white, then he loosed her and looked at her with a sombre expression. She thought she had won, and continued: 'I tell you I belong to my Phoebus, it's Phoebus I love, it's Phoebus who is so handsome! You, priest, you are old! you are ugly! Go away!'

He let out a violent cry, like a wretch being burned by the red-hot iron. 'Die then!' he said through grinding teeth. She saw his frightful look and tried to flee. He seized her, shook her, threw her to the ground, and hurried towards the corner of the Tour-Roland, dragging her behind him over the pavement by her lovely hands.

Once there, he turned to her: 'One last time, will you be mine?'

She replied forcefully: 'No.'

At that he cried loudly: 'Gudule! Gudule! here's the gypsy girl! Take your revenge!'

The girl felt her elbow roughly seized. She looked. It was an emaciated arm coming out of the window slit in the wall and holding her in a grip of iron.

'Hold her tight!' said the priest. 'It's the gypsy who escaped. Don't let her go. I'll go and fetch the sergeants. You'll see her hang.'

From inside the wall a throaty laugh responded to these bloodthirsty words. 'Ha! ha! ha!' The gypsy saw the priest run off in the direction of the Pont Notre-Dame. A troop of riders could be heard from over there.

The girl had recognized the spiteful recluse. Panting with terror she tried to pull free. She twisted about, heaved convulsively several times in agony and despair, but the other held her with extraordinary strength. The lean, bony fingers which were

bruising her clutched her flesh and met round it. It was as though that hand were riveted to her arm. It was more than a chain, more than a shackle, more than an iron ring: it was living, intelligent pincers emerging from a wall.

Exhausted, she fell back against the wall, and then the fear of death took hold of her. She thought of all the beauty in life, youth, the sight of the sky, aspects of nature, love, Phoebus, of all that was fleeing away from her and all that was coming closer, the priest denouncing her, the executioner who was coming, the gibbet standing there. Then she felt horror rise to the roots of her hair, and she heard the dismal laugh of the recluse whispering: 'Ha! ha! you're going to be hanged!'

Half dead she turned to the window, and saw the *sachette's* wild face through the bars. 'What have I done to you?' she said almost unconscious.

The recluse did not answer, but began mumbling in a singsong tone, angry and mocking: 'Daughter of Egypt! daughter of Egypt! daughter of Egypt!'

The unfortunate Esmeralda dropped her head beneath her hair, realizing that she was not dealing with a human being.

Suddenly the recluse cried out, as though the gypsy's question had taken all that time to get through to her mind: 'What have you done to me? you say! Ah! what have you done to me, gypsy woman! All right! listen. I had a child, yes I did, do you see? I had a child! a child, I say!—a pretty little girl!—my Agnès,' she went on, distraught, kissing some object in the shadows. 'Well! do you see, daughter of Egypt? They took my child away, they stole my child, they ate my child. That's what you've done.'

The girl answered, like the lamb in the story: 'Alas! I may not even have been born then!'

'Oh yes!' retorted the recluse, 'you must have been born. You were one of them. She would be your age! So—for fifteen years now I've been here, fifteen years I've been suffering, fifteen years I've been praying, fifteen years I've been banging my head against these four walls. I tell you, it's the gypsy women who stole her from me, do you hear? and ate her with their teeth. Do you have a heart? Imagine what it's like, a child playing, a child feeding at the breast, a child sleeping. It's so innocent! Well! that's what they took from me, what they killed! The good Lord knows! Today it's my turn, I'm going to eat gypsy!—Oh! how I'd bite you if the bars didn't get in the

way. My head's too big!—Poor little thing! while she was asleep! And if they woke her up when they took her, it was no good her crying, I wasn't there!—Ah! you gypsy mother, you've eaten my child! Come and see yours!'

Then she started to laugh, or grind her teeth, the two looked much the same in that ferocious face. Day was beginning to break. An ashen glint dimly lit up this scene, and the gibbet stood out more and more distinctly in the square. In the other direction, over towards the Pont Notre-Dame, the poor condemned girl thought she could hear the sound of cavalry coming closer.

'Madame!' she cried, hands clasped, down on her knees, dishevelled, distraught, wild with fright, 'madame! have pity. They are coming. I have done nothing to you. Do you want to see me die so horribly before your eyes? You can feel pity, I'm sure. It's too awful. Let me run away! Loose me! Mercy! I don't want to die like that!'

'Give me back my child!' said the recluse.

'Mercy! mercy!'

'Give me back my child!'

'Loose me, in heaven's name!'

'Give me back my child!'

This time the girl fell back once more, exhausted, broken, her eyes already glazed like someone in the grave. 'Alas!' she stammered, 'you are looking for your child. I am looking for my parents.'

'Give me back my little Agnès!' Gudule continued. 'You don't know where she is? Die then!—I'm going to tell you. I was a loose woman, I had a child, they took my child from me—it was the gypsy women. You can see that you must die. When your gypsy mother comes to claim you, I'll tell her: "Mother, look at that gibbet!" Or give me back my child—do you know where my little girl is? Wait, I'll show you. Here's her shoe, all that I have left of her. Do you know where the matching one is? If you know, tell me, and if it's only the other end of the world, I'll go and fetch it walking on my knees.'

As she said this, with her other arm stretched out of the window she showed the gypsy the little embroidered shoe. It was already light enough to make out its shape and colours.

'Show me that shoe,' said the gypsy, giving a start. 'God! God!' And at the same time, with her free hand, she swiftly opened the little bag decorated with green glass beads which she wore round her neck.

'Go on! go on!' muttered Gudule, 'rummage in your devilish amulet!' Suddenly she broke off, trembled in every limb, and cried out in a voice which came from her innermost depths: 'My daughter!'

The gypsy had just pulled out of the bag a little shoe exactly matching the other one. Attached to this little shoe was a scrap of parchment on which was written this verse:

When you find the pair to this shoe,
Your mother will stretch out her arms to you.

Quicker than a flash of lightning, the recluse had compared the two shoes, read the inscription on the parchment, and pressed her face, radiant with heavenly joy, to the window bars, crying out: 'My daughter! my daughter!'

'Mother!' answered the gypsy.

Here we give up any attempt at description.

The wall and the iron bars stood between them.

'Oh! the wall!' cried the recluse. 'Oh! to see her and not embrace her! Your hand! your hand!'

The girl passed her arm through the window, the recluse threw herself upon that hand, fastened her lips to it and stayed, plunged in that kiss, showing no other sign of life than a sob which made her body heave from time to time. Meanwhile she wept torrents, in silence, in darkness, like rainfall at night. The poor mother poured out in streams over this adored hand the deep, black well of tears within her, into which all her grief had filtered drop by drop for fifteen years.

Suddenly she stood up, pushed her long grey hair away from her forehead and without saying a word began shaking the bars of her cell with both hands more furiously than a lioness. The bars held firm. Then she went to fetch from a corner of the cell a big paving-stone which served her as a pillow, and hurled it at the bars so violently that one broke in a shower of sparks. A second blow completed the collapse

of the old iron crossbar which blocked the window. Then using both hands she finished breaking and pushing clear the rusty stumps of the bars. There are moments when a woman's hands have superhuman strength.

Once a way through had been cleared, and that took less than a minute, she seized her daughter round the waist and pulled her into the cell. 'Come! let me fish you back from the abyss!' she murmured.

When her daughter was inside the cell, she gently laid her on the ground, then picked her up again, and carrying her in her arms as though she was still the baby Agnès, walked up and down in the harrow cell, intoxicated, out of her mind with joy, shouting, singing, kissing her daughter, talking to her, roaring with laughter, bursting into tears, all at the same time, in a frenzy.

'My daughter, my daughter!' she said. 'I've got my daughter! Here she is. The good Lord has restored her to me. Hey you! come here all of you! Is there anyone there to see that I've got my daughter? Lord Jesus, how beautiful she is! You kept me waiting fifteen years, merciful God, but that was so she would be beautiful when you gave her back. So the gypsy women had not eaten her! Who told me so? My little girl! my little girl! kiss me. Those good gypsy women! I love gypsy women. It's really you. So that's why my heart leaped each time you went by. But there was I taking that for hatred! Forgive me. Agnès, forgive me. You thought I was very spiteful, didn't you? I love you.—That little mark on your neck, do you still have it? Let's see. She's still got it. Oh! you are beautiful! You got those great big eyes from me, mademoiselle. Kiss me. I love you. I don't mind other mothers having children, I don't care about them now. They have only to come here. Here's mine. There's her neck, her eyes, her hair, her hand. Try and find anything as beautiful as that! Oh! I can assure you that she'll have lots of men in love with her, that one! All my beauty has gone, and passed to her. Kiss me!'

She said countless other extravagant things to her, to which the tone alone lent beauty, disarranged the poor girl's clothing to the point of making her blush, smoothed out her silken hair with her hand, kissed her foot, her knee, her forehead, her eyes, went into raptures about everything. The girl submitted to it all, repeating at intervals, very softly and with infinite gentleness: 'Mother!'

'You see, my little girl,' the recluse went on, punctuating each word with kisses,

'you see, I'll love you dearly. We'll go away from here. We're going to be really happy. I've inherited something at Reims, the part of the country we come from. Reims, you know? Ah! no, you don't know it, you were too small! If you knew how pretty you were at four months! Such tiny feet that people came to see them out of curiosity from Épernay, and that's seven leagues distant! We'll have a field, a house, I'll have you sleep in my bed. My goodness! my goodness! Who would ever believe it? I've got my daughter!'

'O mother!' the girl said, finally finding enough strength to speak in her emotion, 'the gypsy woman did tell me. There was a good gypsy woman of our people who died last year, and always cared for me like a foster mother. She was the one who put that little bag round my neck. She always used to say to me: "Little one, look after this jewel. It's a treasure. It will enable you to find your mother again. You are wearing your mother round your neck." She had foretold it, that gypsy had.'

The *sachette* once more hugged her daughter. 'Come here, let me kiss you! You say that so nicely. When we are back home, we'll put those little shoes on an Infant Jesus in one of the churches. We certainly owe that to the good Holy Virgin. Goodness, what a pretty voice you have! When you were talking to me just now it was like music! Oh! my Lord God! I have found my child! But who would ever believe such a story? Nothing is going to make us die, for I haven't died of joy!'

Then she started clapping her hands again, laughing and shouting: 'We are going to be happy!'

At that moment the cell rang with the clanking of weapons and the noise of galloping horses which seemed to emerge from the Pont Notre-Dame and to be approaching nearer and nearer along the quay. The gypsy flung herself in anguish into the *sachette's* arms.

'Save me! save me! mother! They are coming!'

The recluse went pale.

'Oh! heavens! What are you saying? I had forgotten! They are pursuing you! But what have you done?'

'I don't know,' the unhappy child replied, 'but I have been condemned to death.'

'To death!' said Gudule, staggering as though struck by a thunderbolt. 'To death!'

she went on slowly, staring fixedly at her daughter.

'Yes, mother,' the girl went on, quite distraught, 'they want to kill me. They are coming now to take me. That gallows is for me! Save me! save me! They're coming! Save me!'

The recluse stood quite still for a few moments as if turned to stone, then shook her head doubtingly, and suddenly let out a roar of laughter, but with her mad, terrifying laugh which had come back: 'Oh! oh! no! it's a dream that you're telling me. Ah, yes! I lose her, and that lasts fifteen years, then I find her again and that lasts one minute! And they are going to take her away again! And it's now that she is beautiful, grown up, talking to me, loving me, it's now they come to devour her, before my eyes, I, her mother! Oh no! Such things are not possible. The good God doesn't allow things like that.'

Now the cavalcade appeared to halt, and a distant voice could be heard saying: 'Over here, Messire Tristan! The priest says we'll find her at the Rat-hole.' The sound of horses began again.

The recluse stood upright with a desperate cry. 'Flee, flee, my child! It all comes back to me. You are right. It is your death! Horrors! malediction! flee!'

She put her head out of the window and quickly withdrew it.

'Stay,' she said, in a low voice, curt and mournful, convulsively squeezing the hand of the gypsy, who was more dead than alive. 'Stay! don't breathe! There are soldiers everywhere. You can't go out. It's too light.'

Her eyes were dry and burning. She stayed for a moment without speaking. She just strode about the cell, stopping periodically to rip out handfuls of grey hair, and then tore them with her teeth.

Suddenly she said; 'They are coming closer. I'll talk to them. Hide in that corner. They won't see you. I'll just tell them you escaped, that I let you go.'

She put her daughter down, for she was still carrying her, in a corner of the cell which could not be seen from outside. She made her crouch down, carefully arranging her so that neither her hand nor her foot emerged from the darkness, undid her black hair and spread it over her white dress to conceal it, and put the pitcher and paving-stone, the only furniture she had, in front of the girl, imagining that the pitcher and

paving stone would hide her. When that was done, now calmer, she knelt down and prayed. Day, which was only just breaking, still left plenty of dark corners in the Rat-hole.

At that moment the priest's voice, that voice out of hell, passed right by the cell, shouting: 'Over here, Captain Phoebus de Châteaupers!'

At that name, that voice, la Esmeralda, crouching in her corner, made a movement. 'Don't stir!' said Gudule.

She had scarcely finished speaking before a tumult of men, swords, and horses halted round the cell. The mother quickly stood up and took up a position in front of the window to block it. She saw a great body of armed men, on foot and on horseback, drawn up on the Grève. Their commander dismounted and came over to her. 'Old woman,' said this man, who had a most cruel face, 'we are looking for a witch to hang her; we've been told you had her.'

The poor mother put on the most casual air she could, and answered: 'I'm not sure what you mean.'

The other went on: 'God's head! What was that tale that archdeacon was making all that fuss about then? Where is he?'

'My lord,' a soldier said, 'he's vanished.'

'Now then, you crazy old woman,' the commander continued, 'don't lie to me. You were given a witch to guard. What have you done with her?'

The recluse did not want to deny everything, for fear of arousing suspicion, and replied in a tone of surly sincerity: 'If you're talking about a tall girl they gave me to hold just now, I can tell you that she bit me and I let her go. There. Leave me in peace.'

The commander made a grimace of disappointment.

'Don't go lying to me, you old spectre,' he went on. 'My name is Tristan l'Hermite and I'm the King's *compère*. Tristan l'Hermite, do you hear?' He added, looking around him at the Place de Grève: 'It's a name with echoes around here.'

'Even if you were Satan l'Hermite,' Gudule replied, regaining hope, 'I wouldn't tell you any different and I wouldn't be afraid of you.'

'God's head!' said Tristan, 'what an old harridan! Ah! so the witch girl escaped!'

Which way did she go?’

Gudule answered in a tone of indifference: ‘The rue du Mouton, I think.’

Tristan turned his head, and signalled to his troop to prepare to move off again. The recluse breathed again.

‘My lord,’ one of the archers said suddenly, ‘ask the old hag why the bars on her window are all broken like that.’

The question brought anguish back into the wretched mother’s heart. She did not, however, lose all presence of mind: ‘They’ve always been like that,’ she stammered.

‘Oh no!’ retorted the archer, ‘only yesterday they formed a fine black cross which gave people pious thoughts.’

Tristan cast a sidelong look at the recluse. ‘I think the old girl is getting upset!’

The luckless woman realized that everything depended on putting on a bold face, and with death in her heart she began to snigger. Mothers have that kind of strength. ‘Tush!’ she said, ‘the man’s drunk. More than a year ago the tail of a cart carrying stones hit my window and smashed in the grating. I can tell you, I gave the carter a piece of my mind!’

‘That’s true,’ said another archer, ‘I was there.’

There are always people everywhere who have seen everything. The unhopd-for testimony of the archer put new spirit into the recluse for whom this interrogation was like crossing over an abyss on a knife-edge.

But she was condemned to continual alternation of hope and alarm.

‘If a cart did that,’ the first soldier retorted, ‘the stumps of the bars should be pushed inwards, whereas they are bent outwards.’

‘Ha! ha!’ Tristan said to the soldier, ‘you’ve got a nose like an investigator at the Châtelet. Answer what he says, old woman!’

‘For goodness’ sake!’ she cried, feeling cornered, and in a tearful voice despite herself, ‘I swear to you, my lord, that it was a cart that broke those bars. You’ve heard that this man saw it. Anyhow, what’s that got to do with your gypsy?’

‘The devil!’ went on the soldier, flattered by the Provost’s praise, ‘the breaks in the iron are quite fresh!’

Tristan nodded. She went pale. 'How long ago, do you say, was this cart business?'

'A month, maybe two weeks, my lord. I don't remember.'

'First of all she said more than a year,' observed the soldier.

'That's suspicious!' said the Provost.

'My lord,' she cried, still pressed up against the window, trembling with fear lest suspicion should prompt them to stick their heads through and look into the cell, 'my lord, I swear to you that it was a cart broke this grating. I swear by the holy angels in paradise. If it was not a cart, may I be eternally damned and I deny God.'

'You're putting a lot of warmth into that oath!' said Tristan with his inquisitorial look.

The poor woman felt her assurance slipping away more and more. She had begun making blunders, and realized with terror that she was not saying what she should have said.

At this point another soldier arrived, shouting: 'My lord, the old hag is lying. The witch didn't escape by the rue du Mouton. The chain has been stretched across the street all night, and the chain-keeper has seen no one go by.'

Tristan, whose expression was becoming more sinister every moment, addressed the recluse: 'What do you have to say to that?'

She tried once more to face up to this new incident. 'I don't know, my lord, I may have been mistaken. I think she crossed the water, in fact.'

'That's in the opposite direction,' said the Provost. 'It's not very likely, though, that she'd want to go back to the Cité where they were pursuing her. You're lying, old woman!'

'Anyhow,' added the first soldier, 'there isn't a boat on this side of the water or on the other.'

'She must have swum across,' replied the recluse, defending her ground inch by inch.

'Can women swim?' asked the soldier.

'God's head! old woman! you're lying! you're lying!' Tristan angrily went on. 'I've a good mind to drop this witch hunt and take you in. Perhaps a quarter of an hour of the question will drag the truth out of you. Come on! You'll come along with us.'

She seized on his words eagerly—'As you wish, my lord. Go on. Go on. The question, I don't mind. Take me along. Quick! quick! Let's go right away.' During that time, she was thinking, my daughter can escape.

'God's death!' said the Provost, 'how greedy she is for the rack! I can't make head nor tail of this mad old woman.'

A grizzled old sergeant of the watch stepped forward and addressed the Provost: 'Mad, indeed, my lord! If she let the gypsy go, it's not her fault, for she has no liking for gypsies. I've done fifteen years in the watch, and every evening I've heard her cursing gypsy women and calling down endless execrations on them. If the one we are after is, as I believe, the little dancer with the goat, she hates her above all.'

Gudule made an effort and said: 'Above all that one.'

The unanimous testimony of the men of the watch confirmed the old sergeant's words for the Provost. Despairing of getting anything out of the recluse, Tristan l'Hermite turned his back on her and with inexpressible anxiety she saw him walk slowly towards his horse. 'Come on,' he said between his teeth, 'on our way! Resume the search. I shan't sleep until the gypsy girl has been hanged.'

He still hesitated a while, however, before mounting his horse. Gudule palpitated between life and death as she watched him scanning the square with the restless look of a hunting-dog that senses the quarry's lair nearby and is reluctant to move away. At last he shook his head and swung into the saddle. Gudule's heart, so horribly compressed, now dilated, and she murmured, casting a glance at her daughter whom she had not yet dared to look at since the men's arrival: 'Saved!'

The poor child had stayed in her corner all that time without breathing or stirring, the image of death standing before her. She had missed nothing of the scene between Gudule and Tristan, and each of her mother's fits of anguish had found an echo in her. She had heard each successive strain. On the thread holding her suspended over the abyss, a score of times she had thought she was about to see it snap, and she was at last beginning to breathe again and feel her feet on firm ground. Just then she heard a voice saying to the Provost:

'*Corbæuf*! Monsieur the Provost, I'm a soldier and it's not my business to hang witches. The rabble has been put down. Allow me to rejoin my company, because it's

without its captain.' The voice was that of Phoebus de Châteaupers. What took place within her defies description. So he was there, her friend, protector, support, refuge, her Phoebus! She stood up, and before her mother could stop her, she hurled herself at the window, crying: 'Phoebus! come to me, my Phoebus!'

Phoebus was no longer there. He had just galloped off round the corner of the rue de la Coutellerie. But Tristan had not gone yet.

The recluse rushed at her daughter roaring. She pulled her back violently, digging her nails into the girl's neck. A mother tigress is not too particular about such details. But it was too late. Tristan had seen.

'Ha! ha!' he cried, with a laugh that bared his teeth and made his face look like a wolf's muzzle, 'two mice in the mouse-hole!'

'I suspected as much,' said the soldier.

Tristan clapped him on the shoulder: 'You make a good cat! Come on,' he added, 'where's Henriette Cousin?'

A man who had neither the dress nor the bearing of the soldiers stepped out of their ranks. He wore a particoloured outfit, half grey, half brown; he had straight hair, leather sleeves, and a bundle of rope in his huge fist. This man was constantly in Tristan's company, as Tristan was constantly in that of Louis XL

'My friend,' said Tristan l'Hermite, 'I presume that's the witch we've been looking for. You'll hang it for me. Have you got your ladder?'

'There's one over in the shed at the Maison-aux-Piliers,' the man answered. 'Is that the gallows we're going to use for the job?' he continued, pointing to the stone gibbet.

'Yes.'

'Ho! ho!' the man went on, with a coarse laugh even more bestial than the Provost's, 'we shan't have far to go.'

'Get a move on,' said Tristan. 'You can laugh afterwards.'

Meanwhile, ever since Tristan had seen her daughter and all hope was lost, the recluse had not uttered a word. She had flung the poor gypsy, half dead, into the corner of the cellar, and had resumed her position at the window, both hands resting on the corner of the ledge like a pair of talons. They saw her in this attitude fearlessly eyeing all those soldiers with a gaze which had become once more wild and crazy.

When Henriët Cousin approached the cell she made such a savage face at him that he fell back.

'My lord,' he said returning to the Provost, 'which one am I to take?'

'The young one.'

'That's good, for the old one looks troublesome.'

'That poor little dancer with her goat!' said the old sergeant of the watch.

Henriët Cousin went back back to the window. The look in the mother's eyes made him lower his own. He said rather timidly:

'Madame ...'

She interrupted in a very low, furious voice: 'What do you want?'

'Not you,' he said, 'the other one.'

'What other one?'

'The girl.'

She began to shake her head and shout: 'There's no one here! There's no one here! There's no one here!'

'Yes, there is,' the hangman went on, 'as you know very well. Let me take the girl. I don't want to hurt you.'

She said with an odd sort of giggle: 'Ah! you don't want to hurt me!'

'Let me take the other one, madame; that is the wish of Monsieur the Provost.'

She repeated crazily: 'There's no one here.'

'I tell you there is!' replied the hangman. 'We've all seen that there are two of you.'

'Take a look!' jeered the recluse. 'Stick your head through the window.'

The hangman studied the mother's fingernails and did not dare.

'Hurry up!' shouted Tristan, who had just posted his troops in a circle round the Rat-hole, and was waiting on horseback beside the gibbet.

Henriët went back to the Provost once more, wholly at a loss. He had put down his rope on the ground, and was awkwardly rolling his hat in his hands. 'My lord,' he asked, 'how do I get in?'

'Through the door.'

'There isn't one.'

'Through the window.'

'It's too narrow.'

'Widen it,' Tristan said angrily. 'Don't you have any picks?'

From the depths of her cave the mother, still in the same position, was watching. She no longer had any hope, she no longer knew what she wanted, but she did not want them to take her daughter away from her.

Henriet Cousin went to fetch the hangman's box of tools from the shed at the Maison-aux-Piliers. He also took from there the double ladder, which he set up right against the gibbet. Five or six men from the Provostry armed themselves with picks and crowbars, and Tristan made his way with them to the window.

'Old woman,' said the Provost in a stern tone, 'hand over that girl to us without any fuss.'

She looked at him like someone failing to understand.

'God's head!' Tristan went on, 'what's wrong with you, trying to prevent the witch from being hanged at the King's pleasure?'

The wretched woman began to laugh her wild laugh. 'What's wrong with me? She's my daughter.'

The tone in which she uttered that word made even Henriet Cousin shudder.

'I'm sorry about that,' the Provost replied. 'But such is the King's good pleasure.'

With her terrible laugh growing even louder she cried: 'What does your king matter to me? I tell you she's my daughter!'

'Break through the wall,' said Tristan.

To make a wide enough opening they had only to dislodge one course of stone underneath the window. When the mother heard the picks and crowbars sapping her fortress, she let out a frightful scream, then began racing round her cell at terrifying speed, a habit of wild animals which she had acquired from being caged up. She did not say anything more, but her eyes blazed. The soldiers' blood ran cold.

Suddenly she picked up her paving stone, laughed, and flung it with both hands at the men working. The stone, badly aimed, for her hands were trembling, did not hit anyone, and came to rest under the hooves of Tristan's horse. She ground her teeth.

Meanwhile, although the sun was not yet up, it was broad daylight, a fine rosy tint brightened up the rotten old chimneys of the Maison-aux-Piliers. It was the hour when the first early-morning windows in the great city open cheerfully upon the roofs. A few peasants, a few fruiterers going to market on their donkeys, were beginning to cross the Grève. They stopped for a moment in front of this body of soldiers massed around the Rat-hole, gazed in amazement, and went on their way.

The recluse had gone to sit down by her daughter, putting her own body in front of her as a shield, her eyes staring, listening to the poor child who did not stir and whose only utterance was a low murmur: 'Phoebus! Phoebus!' As the work of demolition seemed to be making progress, the mother automatically moved back, pressing the girl more and more tightly against the wall. The recluse suddenly saw the stone shift (for she was standing guard and never took her eyes off it), and heard Tristan's voice encouraging the workmen. At that, she emerged from the state of collapse into which she had fallen for a few moments, and cried out, and while she spoke her voice at one moment rent the ear like a saw, at the next stammered as if every possible malediction had crowded upon her lips to burst out simultaneously. 'Oh! oh! This is horrible! You are brigands! Are you really going to take my daughter from me? I tell you she's my daughter! Oh! you cowards! hangman's lackeys! miserable murdering churls! Help! Help! Fire! But are they going to take my child from me just like that? Who is it they call the good God, then?'

Then, foaming at the mouth, wild-eyed, on all fours like a panther, bristling all over, she addressed Tristan: 'Come a bit nearer to take my daughter! Can't you understand that this woman is telling you it's her daughter? Do you know what it is to have a child? Eh, you lynx, haven't you ever lain with your mate? Haven't you ever had a cub? And if you do have little ones, isn't there something inside you that is stirred when they howl?'

'Lower the stone,' said Tristan; 'it's loose now.'

The crowbars raised the heavy stone course. It was, as we have said, the mother's last rampart. She threw herself upon it, tried to hold it back, dug her nails into the stone, but the massive block, set moving by six men, escaped from her and slid gently to the ground along the iron bars.

When the mother saw that they had now made a way in, she fell across the

opening, barricading the breach with her body, wringing her arms, banging her head against the stone floor, and crying in a barely audible voice made hoarse by exhaustion: 'Help! fire! fire!'

'Now take the girl,' said the ever-impassive Tristan.

The mother gave the soldiers such a fearful glare that they felt more like retreating than advancing.

'Go on, then,' the Provost went on. 'You, Henriette Cousin!'

No one moved.

The Provost swore: 'Christ's head! my soldiers! scared of a woman!'

'My lord,' said Henriette, 'do you call that a woman?'

'She has a lion's mane!' said another.

'Go on!' the Provost retorted, 'the opening is wide enough. Go in three abreast, as at the breach at Pontoise. Let's have done, Mahomet's death! The first man who falls back, I'll cut him in two!'

Caught between the Provost and the mother, both threatening, the soldiers hesitated a moment, then, making up their minds, advanced on the Rat-hole.

When the recluse saw that, she abruptly knelt upright, pushed her hair away from her face, then let her torn, skinny hands drop on to her thighs. Then great tears fell from her eyes one by one, and ran down her furrowed cheeks like a torrent in the bed it has scoured out. At the same time she began to speak, but in tones so beseeching, so gentle, so submissive and so harrowing, that around Tristan more than one old sergeant who would have eaten human flesh was wiping his eyes.

'My lords! messieurs the sergeants, one word! There's something I must tell you. She's my daughter, do you see? The dear little daughter I had lost! Listen. It's quite a story. I am well acquainted with messieurs the sergeants, believe me. They were always kind to me at the time when little boys used to throw stones at me because I led a life of shame. You see? you'll let me keep my child when you know! I'm a poor harlot. It was the gypsy women who stole her from me. I've even kept her shoe these fifteen years. Look, here it is! That was her little foot. At Reims! Chantefleurie! rue Folle-Peine! You may have known it. That was me. When you were young, those were good times. We had some merry moments. You'll have pity on me, won't you my

lords? The gypsies stole her from me, they hid her from me for fifteen years. I thought she was dead. Imagine, my good friends, I thought she was dead. I've spent fifteen years in this cellar, without a fire in winter. That's hard, that is. Poor dear little shoe! I cried out so much that the good Lord heard me. Last night he gave me back my daughter. It was a miracle from the good Lord. She wasn't dead. You won't take her from me, I'm sure. Now, if it was me, I wouldn't say that, but her, a child of 16! Let her have time to see the sun! What's she done to you? Nothing at all. Nor have I—if only you knew that she's all I've got, that I am old, that she's a blessing sent to me by the Holy Virgin. And then you are all so kind! You didn't know she was my daughter, but you know now. Oh! I love her! Monsieur the High Provost, I'd rather have a hole in my insides than see a scratch on her finger. You are someone who looks like a kind lord! What I'm telling you explains it all, doesn't it? Oh! if you ever had a mother, my lord! You are the captain, let me keep my child! Look at me praying to you on my knees as one prays to Jesus Christ! I'm not asking anything from anyone, but I want my child! Oh! I want to keep my child! The good Lord, who is the master, didn't give her back to me for nothing! The King! the King, you say! He won't get much pleasure from having my little girl killed! And he's a kind king too! She's my daughter! my daughter, mine! She doesn't belong to the King! She's not yours! I want to go away! We want to go away! Come now, when two women are passing by, one mother, the other daughter, you let them through! Let us through! We're from Reims. Oh! you're very kind, messieurs the sergeants, I love you all. You won't take my dear little daughter from me, you can't! It's quite impossible, isn't it? My child! my child!

We shall not attempt to give any idea of her gestures, her tone, the tears she swallowed as she spoke, the way she clasped and then wrung her hands, her heart-rending smiles, her tearful glances, the groans, the sighs, the chilling cries of misery mingled with her muddled, crazy, incoherent words. When she fell silent, Tristan l'Hermite frowned, but that was to hide a tear welling up into his tigerish eye. He overcame that weakness, however, and said curtly: 'It is the King's will.'

Then he bent over Henriette Cousin's ear and whispered: 'Get it over quickly!' Perhaps even the formidable Provost felt his heart failing him.

The hangman and the sergeants entered the cell. The mother offered no resistance, she just dragged herself over to her daughter and threw herself headlong over her.

The gypsy saw the soldiers approaching. The horror of death revived her. 'Mother!' she cried in tones of indescribable distress, 'mother! They're coming! Defend me!'

'Yes, my love, I'll defend you!' her mother answered in a feeble voice, and hugging her tightly in her arms smothered her with kisses. The two of them lying like that upon the ground, the mother on top of her daughter, made a pitiable sight.

Henriet Cousin grasped the girl round the middle, under her lovely shoulders. When she felt his hand she gasped: 'Ugh!' and fainted. The hangman, shedding great tears on her, drop by drop, tried to pick her up in his arms. He attempted to pull the mother loose, for she had, so to speak, knotted both hands around her daughter's waist, but she clung to the child so tenaciously that it was impossible to separate them. So Henriet Cousin dragged the girl out of the cell, with her mother behind her. The mother too kept her eyes closed.

The sun was coming up just at that moment, and there was already a considerable crowd of people gathered in the square, watching from a distance to see who it was being dragged like that over the pavement to the gibbet. For such was Provost Tristan's custom at executions. He had a mania for preventing curious spectators from coming anywhere near.

There was no one at the windows, only in the distance, on top of the tower of Notre-Dame that overlooks the Grève, two men could be seen, standing out in black against the clear morning sky, apparently watching.

Henriet Cousin stopped at the foot of the fatal ladder with what he was dragging, and hardly breathing, so moved to pity was he, put the rope round the girl's adorable neck. The unfortunate child felt the horrible touch of the hemp. She opened her eyes, and saw the gaunt arm of the stone gibbet stretched out above her head. Then she shook herself, and cried out in a loud, heart-rending voice: 'No! no! I don't want to!' The mother, whose head was buried and hidden beneath her daughter's clothes, did not say a word; but her whole body could be seen to shudder and she could be heard kissing her daughter more intensely than ever. The hangman took advantage of that moment swiftly to break the grip of the arms with which she clasped the condemned girl. Either from exhaustion or despair, she let him do it. Then he slung the girl over his shoulder, whence the charming creature hung down gracefully, bent double over his massive head. Then he put his foot on the ladder to go up.

At that moment the mother, lying huddled on the paving, fully opened her eyes. She did not utter a cry, but stood up straight with a terrible expression and then hurled herself, like a beast at its prey, upon the hangman's hand and bit him. It happened in a flash. The hangman howled with pain. Some men rushed up. With difficulty they pulled his bleeding hand free from the mother's teeth. She maintained a profound silence. They pushed her away quite brutally, and noticed that her head fell back heavily on the paving. They picked her up again. Again she fell back. She was, in fact, dead.

The hangman, who had not loosed the girl, started up the ladder again.

II

LA CREATURA BELLA BIANCO VESTITA (DANTE)* [THE LOVELY CREATURE ROBED IN WHITE]

WHEN Quasimodo saw that the cell was empty, that the gypsy was no longer there, that while he was defending her she had been abducted, he gripped his hair with both hands and stamped the ground in surprise and grief. Then he began running all over the church, looking for his gypsy, bellowing strange cries at every corner of the walls, scattering his red hair over the pavement. It was exactly at this moment that the King's archers made their victorious entry into Notre-Dame, also looking for the gypsy. Quasimodo helped them, never suspecting, poor deaf creature, their fatal intentions; he believed the gypsy girl's enemies were the truands. He himself led Tristan l'Hermite to all the possible hiding places, opened secret doors for him, false altar backs, inner sacristies. Had the unfortunate girl still been there, he would have been the one to deliver her up. When Tristan, weary at never finding anything, gave up in discouragement, and he was not easily discouraged, Quasimodo continued the search by himself. He went all round the church, twenty, a hundred times, back and forth, from top to bottom, climbing, descending, running, calling, shouting, sniffing, ferreting, rummaging, poking his head into every hole, pushing a torch under every vault, crazy with despair. A male animal who had lost its mate could not have roared more loudly nor been more frantic. At last, when he was sure, quite sure, that she was no longer there, that it was finished, that someone had stolen her from him, he went back slowly up the tower staircase, that staircase he had scaled in such excitement and triumph the day he had rescued her. He passed by the same places, his head drooping, without speaking, without weeping, almost without breathing. The church was once more deserted and plunged into silence. The archers had left it to hunt down the witch in the Cité. Quasimodo, remaining on his own in the vastness of Notre-Dame, a moment before under such tumultuous siege, made his way back to the cell where the gypsy had slept for so many weeks with him as her guard. As he approached it he imagined that he might perhaps find her there. When, at a bend in the gallery overlooking the roof of the side-aisles, he saw the narrow cell with its little

window and little door, huddled under a huge flying buttress like a bird's nest under a branch, the poor man's heart failed him, and he leaned against a pillar to stop himself falling. He imagined that she might perhaps have returned, that some good spirit had no doubt brought her back, that the little cell was too peaceful, too safe, too delightful for her not to be there, and he dared not take another step for fear of shattering his illusion. 'Yes,' he told himself, 'she may be asleep, or praying. Let's not disturb her.'

He finally gathered up his courage, advanced on tiptoe, looked, and went in. Empty! the cell was still empty. The unhappy deaf man went round it slowly, lifted up the bed and looked underneath, as if she might be hidden between the floor and the mattress, then shook his head and stayed bemused. All of a sudden he furiously stamped out his torch, and without a word or a sigh rushed full tilt to hit his head against the wall and fell unconscious to the floor.

When he came to, he flung himself on the bed, rolled about on it, frantically kissed the place, still warm, where the girl had slept, stayed motionless there for a few minutes as if he was about to expire, then stood up, pouring with sweat, panting, out of his mind, and began banging his head against the walls with the frightening regularity of one of his bell clappers and the determination of a man wanting to break his own skull. At length he fell down a second time, exhausted; he dragged himself out of the cell on his knees, and crouched down facing the door in an attitude of astonishment. He stayed like that for over an hour without stirring, his eye fixed on the deserted cell, more gloomy and pensive than a mother sitting between an empty cradle and a full coffin. He did not utter a word; only, at long intervals, a sob violently shook his whole body, but it was a sob without tears, like summer lightning which makes no sound.

It was apparently then that, as he was trying to work out in the depths of his desolate reflections who could so unexpectedly have abducted the gypsy, he thought of the archdeacon. He remembered that Dom Claude was the only person with a key to the staircase leading to the cell, he recalled his nocturnal attempts on the girl, the first of which Quasimodo had assisted, the second prevented. He recalled countless details, and soon no longer doubted that the archdeacon had taken the gypsy from him. However, such was his respect for the priest, his gratitude, devotion, love for the man were so deeply rooted in his heart that they held out even at that moment

against the claws of jealousy and despair.

He reflected that the archdeacon had done this thing, and the bloody, murderous anger which he would have felt against anyone else turned, once Claude Frollo was involved, into an increase in the poor man's grief.

Just when his thoughts were thus fixed upon the priest, as dawn whitened the flying buttresses, he saw on the upper storey of Notre-Dame, at the angle in the outer balustrade which runs round the apse, a figure walking. This figure was coming in his direction. He recognized it. It was the archdeacon. Claude was pacing slowly and solemnly. He was not looking ahead as he walked, he was making for the north tower, but his face was turned to the side, towards the right bank of the Seine, and he held his head high, as though he were trying to see something over the rooftops. Owls often present this oblique attitude. They fly in one direction and look towards another—the priest thus passed by above Quasimodo without seeing him.

The deaf man, who had been petrified by this sudden apparition, saw him disappear under the doorway to the north tower staircase. The reader knows that it is from this tower that one can see the Hôtel de Ville. Quasimodo rose and followed the archdeacon.

Quasimodo climbed the tower stairs for the sake of climbing them, to find out why the priest was climbing them. For the rest, the poor bellringer did not know what he, Quasimodo, would do, what he would say, what he wanted. He was filled with fury, and filled with fear. The archdeacon and the gypsy clashed in his heart.

When he reached the top of the tower, before coming out of the shadows of the staircase and going on to the platform, he looked cautiously to see where the priest was. The priest had his back to him. There is an open-work balustrade running round the bell-tower platform. The priest was gazing down upon the town, with his chest resting on that one of the four sides of the balustrade which looks out on the Pont Notre-Dame.

Quasimodo came up stealthily behind him to see what he was looking at. The priest's attention was so taken up elsewhere that he did not hear the deaf man's steps behind him.

Paris is a splendid and attractive sight, the Paris of those days especially, seen

from the top of the tower of Notre-Dame in the fresh light of a summer dawn. That day it might have been July. The sky was perfectly clear. A few lingering stars were fading out at various points, and there was one very brilliant one in the east in the brightest part of the sky. The sun was about to come up. Paris was beginning to stir. A very pure, white light brought out vividly to the eye all the different planes which the hundreds of houses present to the east. The gigantic shadow of the church towers went from roof to roof, from one end of the great city to the other. Some districts were already talking and making a noise. Here a bell rang out, there a hammer, over there the complex clatter of a moving cart. Already here and there smoke poured out over this whole surface, as though from the fissures of some immense sulphur field. The river, water ruffling against the arches of so many bridges, the tips of so many islands, was all a-shimmer with silvery pleats. Round the city, outside the ramparts, the eye was lost in a great ring of fluffy vapours through which one could dimly discern the indefinite line of the plains and the graceful swelling of the hills. All sorts of sounds drifted and scattered all over the city, now half awake. Over to the east the morning breeze chased across the sky a few white shreds of cottonwool torn from the hazy fleece covering the hills.

Down in the Parvis some good women, carrying their milk-jugs, pointed out to each other in astonishment the strangely dilapidated state of the main door of Notre-Dame, and two congealed streams of lead between the cracks in the sandstone. That was all that remained of the previous night's tumult. The pyre that Quasimodo had lit between the towers had gone out. Tristan had already cleaned up the square and had the dead thrown into the Seine. Kings like Louis XI take care to wash down the pavement quickly after a massacre.

Beyond the tower balustrade, exactly beneath the spot where the priest had stopped, there was one of those fancifully carved stone waterspouts which bristle all over Gothic buildings, and in a crevice of this spout, two pretty wallflowers in bloom, shaking and almost brought alive by the breeze, were greeting each other with playful bows. Above the towers, far up in the sky, faint bird-cries could be heard.

But the priest was neither listening nor looking at any of this. He was one of those men for whom there are no mornings, no birds, no flowers. In all that vast horizon, with such diverse aspects all around him, his contemplation was concentrated on a

single point.

Quasimodo was burning to ask him what he had done with the gypsy. But at that moment the archdeacon seemed not to be of this world. He was obviously at one of those violent moments in life when one would not feel the earth crumble. With his eyes fixed unwaveringly on a certain spot, he remained motionless and silent; and there was something about this silence and immobility so fearsome that the savage bell-ringer trembled before it and did not dare risk a clash. All he did, and it was another way of interrogating the archdeacon, was to follow the direction of his line of sight, and in that way the eye of the unfortunate deaf man fell on the Place de Grève.

Thus he saw what the priest was looking at. The ladder had been put up beside the permanent gibbet. There were a few of the people in the square and a lot of soldiers. A man was dragging over the pavement something white to which something black was attached. The man stopped at the foot of the gibbet.

Here something took place that Quasimodo could not see clearly. It was not that his single eye was any less able to see at long range, but there was a mass of soldiers preventing him from making out everything. Besides, at that moment the sun appeared and such a flood of light overflowed the horizon that it was as though every pointed projection in Paris—spires, chimneys, gables—caught fire at once.

Meanwhile the man began climbing the ladder. Now Quasimodo could see him distinctly. He carried a woman over his shoulder, a girl dressed in white, and the girl had a noose round her neck. Quasimodo recognized her. It was *her*!

Thus the man reached the top of the ladder. There he adjusted the noose. At that point the priest knelt down on the balustrade to have a better view.

The man suddenly pushed the ladder away with a sharp kick of his heel, and Quasimodo, who had been holding his breath for some moments, saw swaying at the end of the rope, some twelve feet above the ground, the unfortunate child with the man crouching with his feet on her shoulders. The rope spun round several times and Quasimodo saw the gypsy's body seized with horrible convulsions. The priest for his part, craning his neck, was gazing with bulging eyes at the dreadful tableau of man and girl, spider and fly.

At the moment of greatest horror, a diabolical laugh, a laugh possible only for one

who is no longer human, burst out from the priest's livid face. Quasimodo could not hear the laugh, but he saw it. The bell-ringer retreated a step or two behind the archdeacon, and suddenly, rushing at him furiously, pushed him in the back with both his huge hands, down into the abyss over which Dom Claude was leaning.

The priest cried: 'Damnation!' and fell.

The rainspout above which he had been leaning broke his fall. He clung to it with desperate hands, and just as he opened his mouth to cry out a second time, he saw passing over the balustrade, above his head, the fearsome, vengeful face of Quasimodo. So he was silent.

The abyss lay beneath him. A fall of more than two hundred feet, and the pavement. In this terrible situation the archdeacon spoke not one word, let out not one groan. He simply writhed about on the spout in the most incredible efforts to climb up again. But his hands had no hold on the granite, his feet just scratched the blackened wall without getting a grip. Those who have climbed up the towers of Notre-Dame know that there is a bulge in the stonework immediately beneath the balustrade. It was on this re-entrant angle that the wretched archdeacon was exhausting himself. He did not have a vertical wall to deal with, but one sloping away under him.

Quasimodo would have needed only to stretch out his hand to haul him back from the gulf, but he simply did not look at him. He was looking at the Grève. Looking at the gibbet. Looking at the gypsy. The deaf man was leaning with his elbows on the balustrade in the place where the archdeacon had been a moment before, and there, never taking his eyes off the only object there was for him in the world at that moment, he stayed unmoving and dumb like a man struck by a thunderbolt, and a long stream of tears flowed silently from that eye which until then had only ever shed a single tear.

Meanwhile the archdeacon was panting. His bald forehead ran with sweat, his nails bled on the stonework, his knees were rubbing raw on the wall. He could hear his cassock, which had caught on the rainspout, tearing and coming unstitched every time he gave a jerk. As a crowning misfortune, the spout ended in a lead pipe which was bending under the weight of his body. The archdeacon could feel this pipe slowly giving way. He told himself, wretched man, that once his hands became too tired to

hold on, once his cassock was completely torn, once the lead pipe finally gave way, he must inevitably fall, and terror gripped his bowels. At times he looked wildly at a kind of narrow ledge some ten feet below, formed by chance in the sculptures, and he begged heaven from the depths of his soul in distress that he might finish out his life on that space of two square feet, even if it were to last a hundred years. Once he looked beneath him, into the abyss; when he raised his head again his eyes were closed and his hair standing on end.

The silence of these two men was frightening. While the archdeacon faced death so horribly a few feet away, Quasimodo wept and looked at the Grève.

The archdeacon, seeing that all his violent efforts served only to weaken the one fragile support left to him, had decided not to move any more. There he was, clasping the spout, hardly breathing, no longer stirring, left with no other movement than that contraction of the belly we experience in dreams when we think we are falling. His staring eyes were open, with a look in them of sickly amazement. Gradually, though, he was losing ground, his fingers were slipping on the spout, he felt more and more how weak his arms were and how heavy his body, how the curved lead pipe holding him up was bending all the time a notch closer to the abyss. He saw beneath him a terrifying sight: the roof of Saint-Jean-le-Rond no bigger than a playing card folded in half. He looked successively at the impassive sculptures of the tower, like him suspended over the precipice, but feeling no terror for themselves nor pity for him. All around him was stone; before his eyes the gaping monsters; below, at the very bottom, in the square, the pavement; above his head Quasimodo weeping.

In the Parvis there were a few groups of honest bystanders, calmly trying to guess who the madman might be who was amusing himself in such a peculiar way. The priest heard them say—for their voices reached up to him, loud and shrill: 'But he'll break his neck!'

Quasimodo wept on.

At length the archdeacon, foaming with rage and terror, realized that it was all to no purpose. However, he gathered up all the strength remaining to him for one last effort. He stiffened up on the spout, pushed away from the wall with both knees, clung by his hands to a crack between the stones, and managed to climb up a foot, perhaps; but this commotion caused the lead spout supporting him suddenly to bend

over. At the same time the cassock ripped apart. At that, feeling everything give way beneath him, with only his stiff and weakening hands still holding on to anything, the unfortunate man closed his eyes and let go of the spout. He fell.

Quasimodo watched him fall.

A fall from such a height is seldom perpendicular. As he was launched into the void, the archdeacon at first fell with head down and both hands extended, then turned over several times. The wind drove him on to the roof of a house where the unfortunate man's body was first smashed. However, he was not dead when he reached it. The bell-ringer saw him still trying to cling to the gable with his fingernails. But the slope was too steep, and he had no strength left. He slid rapidly over the roof like a tile coming off, and rebounded on the pavement. There he did not move again.

Quasimodo then looked up at the gypsy, whose body he could see in the distance, hanging from the gibbet, shuddering in her white dress in the last twitches of the death agony, then he looked down again at the archdeacon stretched out at the foot of the tower, no longer in human shape, and said with a sob that made his deep chest heave: 'Oh! all I have loved!'

III

PHOEBUS' MARRIAGE

TOWARDS evening on that day, when the bishop's judicial officers came to collect from the pavement of the Parvis the archdeacon's dislocated corpse, Quasimodo had disappeared from Notre-Dame.

Many rumours went round concerning this incident. There was no doubt in people's minds that the day had come when, in accordance with their pact, Quasimodo, that is the devil, was to carry off Claude Frollo, that is the sorcerer. It was supposed that he had shattered the body as he took the soul, as monkeys break the shell to eat the nut.

That is why the archdeacon was not interred in consecrated ground.

Louis XI died the following year, in August 1483.

As for Pierre Gringoire, he managed to save the goat and had some success as a writer of tragedy. It seems that after trying a taste of astrology, philosophy, architecture, hermetics, all sorts of follies, he came back to tragedy, the greatest folly of all. That is what he called 'coming to a tragic end'. On the subject of his dramatic triumphs, this is what we read under 1483* in the accounts of the ordinary: 'To Jehan Marchand and Pierre Gringoire, carpenter and composer, who made and composed the mystery performed at the Châtelet in Paris at the entry of Monsieur the Legate, ordering the characters, these being dressed and attired as was requisite for the said mystery, and likewise constructed the scaffolding which was necessary thereto; and for doing this, 100 *livres*.'

Phoebus de Châteaupers also came to a tragic end: he got married.

IV

QUASIMODO'S MARRIAGE

WE have just said that Quasimodo disappeared from Notre-Dame on the day of the gypsy's and the archdeacon's deaths. He was in fact never seen again, and no one knew what had become of him.

During the night following la Esmeralda's execution, the executioner's men had taken down her body from the gibbet and carried it, according to custom, into the cellar at Montfaucon.

Montfaucon was, as Sauval says, 'the most ancient and superb gibbet in the kingdom'. Between the suburbs of the Temple and Saint-Martin, about 160 *toises* * from the walls of Paris, a few crossbow shots from la Courtille, could be seen on the top of a gentle, imperceptible eminence, high enough to be visible for several leagues around, a strangely shaped structure, somewhat resembling a Celtic cromlech, and where human sacrifices were also made.

Imagine, then, crowning a mound of plaster, a huge parallelepiped of masonry, 15 feet high, 30 feet wide, 40 feet long, with a door, an outside ramp and a platform: on this platform stand sixteen enormous pillars of rough stone, 30 feet high, arranged in a colonnade round three of the four sides of the massive structure supporting them, connected at the top by stout beams from which chains hang at intervals; on all these chains, skeletons; nearby on the plain, a stone cross and two secondary gibbets, which seem to be growing like shoots around the central fork; above it all, in the sky, crows perpetually circle. That is Montfaucon.

At the end of the fifteenth century the formidable gibbet, which dated from 1328, was already very dilapidated. The beams were worm-eaten, the chains rusty, the pillars green with mould. The courses of dressed stone were all cracked at their joints, and grass grew on the platform where feet never trod. This monument presented a horrible profile, standing out against the sky, especially at night, when a little moonlight fell upon the white skulls, or when the chill evening wind rattled the chains and skeletons and set everything moving in the dark. The presence of that

gibbet was enough to impart to all its surroundings the most sinister air.

The block of stone which formed the base of this repulsive structure was hollow. A huge cellar had been excavated within, closed by an old, broken-down iron grating, and into it were thrown not only the human remains which came off the chains at Montfaucon, but the bodies of all the wretches executed at the other permanent gibbets in Paris. In this deep charnel house where the dust of so many human beings and so many crimes rotted away together, many of the great of this world, many of the innocent too, came in turn to add their bones, from Enguerrand de Marigni, who inaugurated Montfaucon as victim, and was a just man, down to Admiral de Coligny,* who closed it, and was a just man.

As for Quasimodo's mysterious disappearance, all we have been able to discover is this.

About two years, or eighteen months, after the events which conclude this history, when they came to the cellar to look for the corpse of Olivier le Daim, who had been hanged two days before,* and to whom Charles VIII granted the favour of being buried at Saint-Laurent in better company, they found among all these hideous carcasses two skeletons, one clasping the other in a strange embrace. One of these two skeletons, that of a woman, still wore some tatters of a dress of a material which had once been white, and round the neck they saw a necklace of adrezarach seeds with a little silken bag, decorated with green glass beads, which was open and empty. These objects were of so little value that the hangman had no doubt not wanted them. The other skeleton, which held the first in close embrace, was that of a man. They noticed that the spinal column was curved, the head down between the shoulder blades, and one leg shorter than the other. Moreover, there was no fracture of the vertebrae of the neck, and it was obvious that he had not been hanged. The man to whom the skeleton belonged had therefore come there himself, and died there. When they tried to remove it from the skeleton it embraced, it fell to dust.